

The Under-19 Cricket World Cup was the launchpad for several young talents who should grow up to be stars

VIRAT KOHLI

A classy batsman, also bowls medium pace. Aggressive, but keeps his cool if situation demands.



AFP

TANMAY SRIVASTAVA

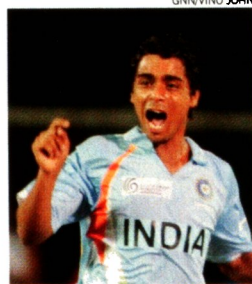
The left-handed batsman and right-arm medium-pacer top-scored for India with 262 runs.



GNN/VINO JOHN

ABDULLAH IQBAL

The left-arm spinner bowls the flatter as well as the loopy version of spin. A captain's delight.



GNN/VINO JOHN

TIMOTHY SOUTHEE

The Kiwi all-rounder impressed all with his match-winning performances. A player for the future.



GNN/VINO JOHN

WAYNE PARNELL

The Protean skipper is a left-arm fast bowler and a very useful middle order batsman.



GNN/VINO JOHN

SYBRAND ENGELBRECHT

Flying saves and catches are the forte of this young South African who also bowls off-spin.



COURTESY: ICC

under-19 World Cup is that the future of Indian batting is alive and kicking. Srivastava, Taruwar Kohli and Srivats Goswami have the talent and the ability to move up a level. Kohli, a cool thinker with the bat, can shift gears with relative ease. Saurabh Tiwari, who hails from Jharkhand—India's ODI skipper M.S. Dhoni's home state—is as instinctive with the bat as his senior.

Whatmore made it very clear that this talented lot would need some more time before they are exposed at the international level. Plus, the traffic jam in the Indian middle order is not going to make things easier for these players who should ideally make up India's bench strength in the next few years.

Teams at the junior World Cup placed different emphases on the event. The Australians lost out due to lack of first-class experience that was evident in other teams, especially from the Indian sub-continent. The Aussies prefer more mature players both in their highest levels of domestic and international cricket. Jennings and Dipak Patel, the former Kiwi off-spinner and U-19 coach, were clear in their mission in Kuala Lumpur. Winning was very important but so was gaining experience by playing tough cricket in tougher conditions.

The junior World Cup was billed as the platform that launched Yuvraj Singh, Mohammed Kaif and Graeme Smith among others.

From an Indian perspective, apart from Yuvraj, Kaif and Piyush Chawla, most others from U-19 teams have faded away. So what does the future look like for the heroes of today?

There is no doubt India's juniors have the talent and the aptitude to excel. The question is will they put in that extra bit of consistent performance at the domestic level, remain patient and keep persevering long enough to muscle into the senior ODI side. Remember, that has an average age of 24.

The author is a Singapore-based radio journalist and a former Bombay University cricketer.

their task, while the spin bowling, led by Ravinder Jadeja and Abdullah Iqbal, was tight. The fielding had its ups and downs though. When Kohli and Sangwan dropped two catches of successive balls in the final, the joke went, "Delhi may just have dropped the World Cup." Despite his post-victory 'aggro'—the result of a verbal joust with the South Africans during the rain break in the final—Kohli led creditably, maintaining control and his cool in tight situations.

The other key backroom architect of the Indian win was coach Dav Whatmore, assigned to the team just before the Malaysia event. Training sessions for the event had begun in February. Whatmore, whose other taste of World Cup victory came with Sri Lanka in 1996 when he plotted the downfall of Australia, had given each

"Let us play as a NATION. Play the best GAME of your life. That is what I told the members of my team."

VIRAT KOHLI, CAPTAIN, U-19 CRICKET TEAM

player in the Under-19 World Cup a game-day plan as well as the freedom to innovate. They went into their Cup with news of the IPL and its heap of glittering rewards filtering through to Malaysia and there was speculation that the talent scouts of the franchisees were in talks with the Indians during the tournament. None of that seemed to have affected the team, their nerveless performance in the final being sufficient proof.

The biggest piece of news from the